



Jamaica

First colonized by the Spanish and then by the English, the Caribbean island of Jamaica achieved independence in 1962. It remains an influential force in Caribbean politics.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous, with lush tropical vegetation. Inaccessible limestone area in the northwest. Low, irregular coastal plains are broken by hills and plateaus.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot and humid at sea level, with temperate mountain areas. Hurricanes are likely June–November.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Social tensions result from vast disparities in wealth, rather than race. Economic and political life is dominated by a few wealthy, long-established families. Many women hold senior positions in public life. Armed crime, much of it narcotics-related, is a problem. Large areas of Kingston, which have their own patois, are ruled by violent gangs. Jamaican music styles are influential worldwide.

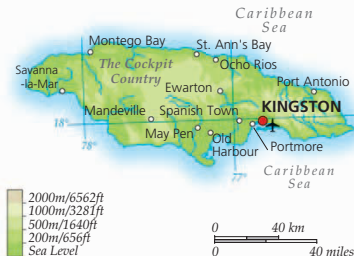


THE ECONOMY

Major bauxite producer, though sector suffering from low world prices. Tourism and light industry. Sugar, bananas, coffee, and rum are exported. Debt burden dominates budget. High underemployment.



INSIGHT: *Jamaica's Rastafarians revere the late emperor of Ethiopia, Haile Selassie, as their spiritual leader, and see Africa as their spiritual home*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Jamaica

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Kingston

POPULATION: 2.72 million

TOTAL AREA: 4243 sq. miles
(10,990 sq. km)

DENSITY: 650 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English Creole, English*

RELIGIONS: Protestant 55%,
other and nonreligious 45%

ETHNIC MIX: Black African 92%,
Mulatto 6%, European and Chinese 1%,
East Indian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Jamaican dollar = 100 cents